

10 Basic Principles of Grieving for Children and Teens

1) Children are concrete in their thinking: In order to lessen their confusion, use the words “death” and “dying.” Describe death concretely. Answer their questions simply and honestly without using euphemisms such as “passed on,” “went to sleep,” etc. You don’t have to add a large number of details. Children will ask if they want to know more. You can see if they are listening because they want to, or if it is for your benefit (they seem agitated, fidgety, and give you little or no eye contact).

2) Children generalize from the specific to the general: If someone died in a hospital, children think that hospitals are for the dying. If someone died in their sleep, children are afraid to go to sleep. If one person died, “someone (or everyone) else will die,” or “I will die.” They will learn to accommodate new truths on their own if they are allowed to express themselves and try things out (e.g., going to sleep and waking up alive).

3) Children are repetitive in their grief: Children may ask questions repetitively. The answers often do not resolve their searching. The searching itself is a part of their grief work. Their questions are indicative of their confusion and uncertainty. Listen and support their searching by answering repetitively and/or telling the story over and over again.

4) Children are physical in their grief: The older children are, the more capable they are of expressing themselves in words. Younger children simply ARE their feelings. What they do with their bodies speaks their feelings. Grief is a physical experience for all ages, but most especially for younger children. Watch their bodies and understand their play as their language of grief. Reflect their play verbally and physically so that they will feel that they are “being heard.” For example, “You are bouncing, bouncing, bouncing on those pillows. Your face is red and you are yelling loudly.”

5) Children grieve cyclically: Their grief work goes in cycles throughout their childhood and their lives. Each time they reach a new developmental level, they reintegrate the important events of their lives, using their newly acquired processes and skills. Example: a one year old, upon losing his mother, will become absorbed in the death again when her language skills develop and as she is able to use words for the expressions of her feelings. She may re-experience the grief again as an adolescent, using her newly acquired cognitive skills of abstract thinking.

6) Children need choices: Death is a disruption in children’s lives that is quite frightening. Their lives will probably seem undependable, unstable, confusing, and out of control. These topsy-turvy feelings can be appeased if children have some say in what they do or don’t do to memorialize the person who has died, and to express their feelings about the death.

“Grief can be the garden of compassion. If you keep your heart open through everything, your pain can become your greatest ally in your life's search for love and wisdom.”

-Rumi

7) Children grieve as part of a family: When a family member dies, it will affect the way the family functions as a whole. All the relationships within the family may shift, adjusting to this change in the family structure. Children will grieve for the person who died, as well as the environment in the family that existed before the death. Children may grieve over the changed behavior of family and friends. It is helpful if each family member is encouraged to grieve in his/her own way, with support for individual differences.

8) Children's feelings are their allies: Feeling help children pay attention to their loss. Through this attention comes their own understanding about the death that they grieve. It is important not to shield children from their emotions; offering them the option to stay or leave will allow them to feel included, and will give them permission to be with the feelings.

9) Children's grief is intertwined with normal developmental tasks: It can be impossible to determine which behaviors are part of developmental phases and which are grief-related (e.g., "Is it adolescence or is it grief?").

10) Key Tasks of Mourning in Children and Teens:

- a. Understand the death, try to make sense of what happened.
- b. Express emotional and other strong responses to the loss.
- c. Commemorate the person that's been lost.
- d. Learn how to go on living and loving.

Let children and teens teach you about their grief.